

The Revolt of 1857

Causes, leaders, key battles, historians' verdicts, and the transfer of power from Company to Crown

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Why this chapter matters: 1857 is the single most heavily tested year in Indian Modern History — SSC pulls from causes, leader-region matching, historians' quotes, and the aftermath almost every cycle. This chapter is dense with "match the following" material, so the tables here are your fastest revision tool.

1 Immediate Cause — The Greased Cartridges

The **Enfield rifle** (Pattern 1853), which required soldiers to bite off the greased end of a cartridge before loading, was introduced to the Bengal Army in **December 1856**. The grease was rumoured to be a mix of **cow and pig fat** — offensive to Hindu soldiers (cow is sacred) and Muslim soldiers (pig is forbidden) alike, making it the spark that united both communities in the ranks.

- The rifle used **before** the Enfield was the "**Brown Bess**" musket, which suffered from dampness/jamming issues and was phased out in its favour.
- Several SSC sources name **Henry Hardinge** as the official who introduced the Enfield rifle in December 1856 — worth flagging that Hardinge's actual term as Governor-General ran 1844–1848, well before this event; the officially serving Governor-General in December 1856 was **Lord Canning**. Different exams may expect either name, so know both.

2 Immediate vs Underlying Causes

When a question asks for the **immediate/proximate** cause specifically, the answer is **military discontent over religious interference** (the greased cartridges) — **not** Dalhousie's Doctrine of Lapse, which is a longer-term political cause and had, in fact, already been discontinued by 1856, before the revolt broke out.

3 Bahadur Shah Zafar & the Symbols of Revolt

- On **11 May 1857**, soldiers from Meerut reached the Red Fort and declared the aging Mughal emperor **Bahadur Shah Zafar** the symbolic leader of the revolt.
- He gave the title "**Shahab-e-Alam Bahadur**" to **Bakht Khan**, who served as his commander-in-chief.
- The revolt's chosen symbols were a **lotus flower and a chapati (roti)**, passed hand to hand as a signal.

4 Begum Hazrat Mahal & Birjis Qadar

Begum Hazrat Mahal led the resistance in **Awadh (Lucknow)**; her son, **Birjis Qadar**, was briefly declared the ruler of Awadh during the revolt.

5 W.H. Russell — The Times Correspondent

The London *Times* correspondent who wrote that in North India, "no one looked kindly on the white man" was **William Howard Russell** — not Gladstone and not Robert Peel, both common wrong options.

6 Where & When It All Began

Event	Date/Place
Mangal Pandey shoots at his officer	29 March 1857, Barrackpore (34th Bengal Native Infantry)
Mangal Pandey hanged	8 April 1857
Main revolt breaks out	Meerut, 10 May 1857 (originally planned for 31 May, but broke out earlier)
Meerut soldiers reach the Red Fort, Delhi	11 May 1857

Event	Date/Place
British recapture Delhi	September 1857

Mangal Pandey's story: He fired at his officer, was wounded and captured, and was hanged on 8 April 1857 at Barrackpore (near Calcutta) — this incident, weeks before Meerut, is often treated as the spark that lit the wider revolt.

7 Regional Leaders — Master Match List

MEMORY TRICK

"My Nani Made Tea for Bakht's Kids" — Nana Saheb (Kanpur) → Maulvi Ahmadullah (Awadh/Lucknow) → Tatya Tope (Gwalior) → Bakht Khan (Delhi) → Kunwar Singh (Bihar).

Leader	Region/Base
Bahadur Shah Zafar / Bakht Khan	Delhi
Nana Saheb	Kanpur
Rani Lakshmibai	Jhansi
Tatya Tope (real name Ramchandra Pandurang)	Gwalior
Begum Hazrat Mahal	Awadh / Lucknow
Maulvi Ahmadullah	Awadh / Lucknow
Kunwar Singh	Jagdishpur, Bihar (Arrah)
Khan Bahadur Khan	Bareilly
Shah Mal	Baraut, Uttar Pradesh (died July 1857)
Nawab Hamid Ali Khan	Ally of Bakht Khan, Delhi
Ram Diwan	Assam

PYQ: Kunwar Singh, a key hero of 1857, is associated with which region? **Ans: Bihar (Jagdishpur/Arrah)**

8 Betrayals & Deaths of the Leaders

- **Tatya Tope** (real name Ramchandra Pandurang) fled to Nepal after the revolt, was lured back to India by his friend **Man Singh** in 1859, captured by the British, and executed the same year.
- **Rani Lakshmibai** died fighting at the **Battle of Gwalior, 18 June 1858**; she was betrayed by the ruler (Scindia) of Gwalior, who sided with the British.
- **Bahadur Shah Zafar** was exiled to **Rangoon in September 1858** and died there in **1862** (as covered in Part 3).

9 Who Helped the British?

The **Scindias of Gwalior** gave the British the most significant support during the revolt. **Raja Mehtab Chand** also supported the British during both the Santhal rebellion and 1857. By contrast, the **Holkars of Indore refused to help the British** — and **Shahamat Khan of Indore** actually took up arms against them.

10 British Officers Who Died at Lucknow

Four notable British figures lost their lives in and around the **Siege of Lucknow**: **General Neill**, **General Havelock**, and **Henry Lawrence** — Lawrence was fatally wounded during fighting connected to the **Battle of Chinhat** (fought in Lucknow). **John Nicholson**, by contrast, survived Lucknow-area fighting (he was fatally wounded later, at Delhi).

11 Why the Revolt Failed

- **Lack of unity** among the rebels — no single overall leader, and each regional leader fought for local/personal goals (e.g. Rani Lakshmibai fought primarily to save Jhansi, not to expel the British nationally).
- **No common plan or central organisation.**
- **No real Hindu-Muslim unity concept** as a unifying ideology.
- **Limited geographical spread** — the revolt's area of real influence was limited, concentrated mainly in the Gangetic plain.

Why British Rajput states saw the revolt fail so easily: Local Rajput rulers largely did **not** support the rebels — without the backing of local rulers, the uprising in those regions was suppressed quickly.

12 Historians' Verdicts — Who Called It What

Historian	Verdict/Label
T.R. Holmes	"Sepoy Mutiny" — wrote a book on the subject; called it a war between "barbarism and civilisation"
James Outram & William Taylor	A "Muslim conspiracy" against the British
Lawrence & Seeley	A "military mutiny"
L.E.R. Rees	A "war of fanatics against Christians"
V.D. Savarkar	India's "First War of Independence" — book: <i>The Indian War of Independence, 1857</i>
R.C. Majumdar	Disagreed — called it "neither first, nor national, nor a war of independence"

PYQ: Which historian called the 1857 revolt "neither first, nor national, nor a war of independence"? **Ans: R.C. Majumdar**

13 Written Accounts of the Revolt

- The **first Indian to write about the causes of 1857 in an Indian language** was **Sir Syed Ahmad Khan** (also founder of the Aligarh/Oriental college), in his Urdu-language book *Asbab-e-Baghawat-e-Hind* ("The Causes of the Indian Revolt"), published in **1859**.
- **V.D. Savarkar's** book was originally published in **English**, in the early 20th century.
- The **official post-Independence historian** chosen to document the Indian freedom movement, including 1857, is generally identified as **S.N. Sen**.

14 Paintings Inspired by 1857

Painting	Artist
"Relief of Lucknow"	Thomas Jones Barker
"In Memoriam" (dedicated to British women in India)	Joseph Noel Paton

15 How & When the Revolt Was Suppressed

The British marked their decisive turnaround with the **Relief of Lucknow**; by **1859**, the revolt was considered completely suppressed nationwide.

16 Queen Victoria's Proclamation (1858)

On **1 November 1858**, **Lord Canning** read out Queen Victoria's Proclamation at **Minto Park, Allahabad**, declaring that **India was now under the direct control of the British Crown** — ending East India Company rule.

Of the many promises made in the 1858 Proclamation, which one was actually kept? The proclamation promised religious non-interference, equal treatment for Indians and Europeans, and preservation of princely states' status — none of these were genuinely honoured. The **one promise that was kept** was the formal **abolition of the Doctrine of Lapse**.

PYQ: Who announced that India was under the British Crown, and when? **Ans: Lord Canning, 1 November 1858**

17 Peel Commission & Army Reorganisation

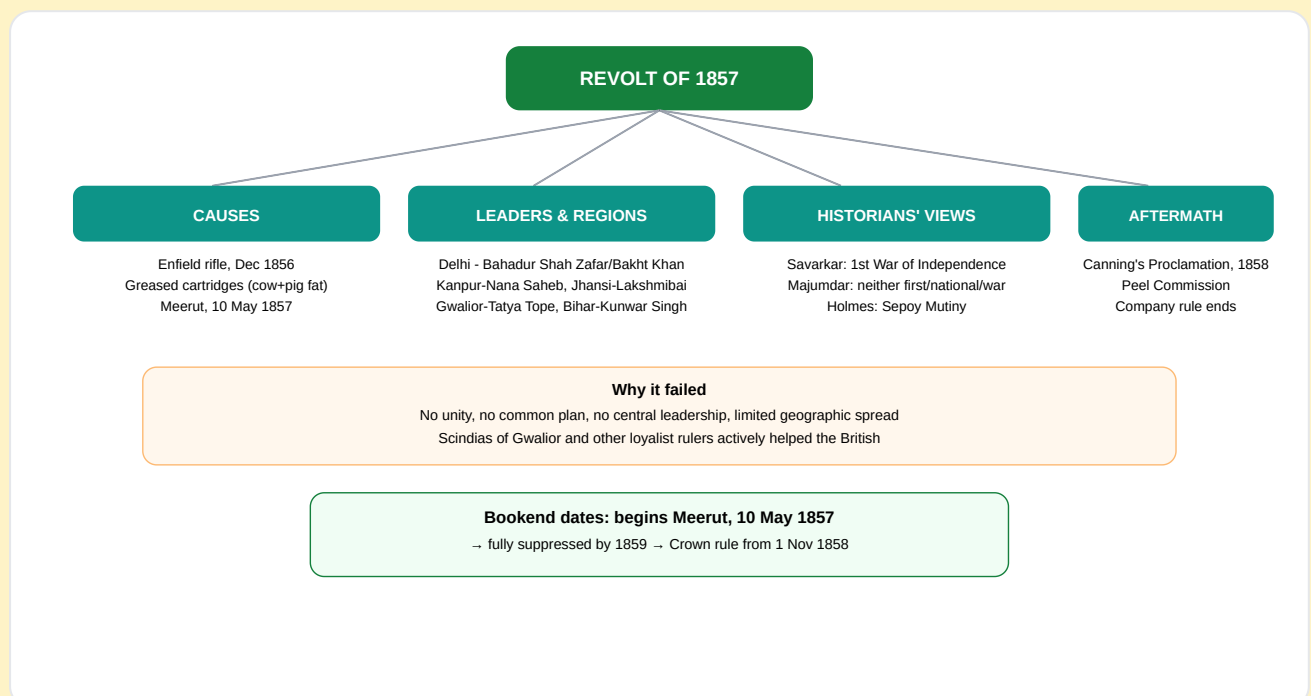
After 1857, the British set up the **Peel Commission** to recommend reforms for reorganising the Indian Army (not to be confused with the later **Hunter Commission**, formed after the 1919 Jallianwala Bagh massacre).

Post-1857 recruitment changes: Brahmins from UP and Bihar, and Bengalis/Oriyas from the East, were largely **excluded** from army recruitment (seen as unreliable after the revolt); recruitment instead favoured **Gurkhas, Sikhs, and Punjabis** — the origin of the colonial-era "martial races" recruitment policy.

18 Master Reference Table

Superlative / Record	Answer
Enfield rifle introduced	December 1856
Rifle used before Enfield	Brown Bess
Revolt began at	Meerut, 10 May 1857
Mangal Pandey's incident	29 March 1857, Barrackpore, 34th BNI
Symbol of the revolt	Lotus flower and chapati
Bahadur Shah Zafar's commander-in-chief	Bakht Khan, titled "Shahab-e-Alam Bahadur"
Begum Hazrat Mahal's son	Birjis Qadar
Real name of Tatyā Tope	Ramchandra Pandurang
Rani Lakshmibai died at	Battle of Gwalior, 18 June 1858
Most helpful royal family to the British	Scindias of Gwalior
"First War of Independence" (author)	V.D. Savarkar
"Neither first, nor national..." (author)	R.C. Majumdar
First Indian-language book on 1857's causes	Sir Syed Ahmad Khan, Urdu, 1859
Crown takeover announced by	Lord Canning, 1 Nov 1858
Commission for army reorganisation	Peel Commission
"Nursery of the Bengal Army"	Awadh

19 Mind Map — Revolt of 1857



20 30-Second Revision

Fact	Value
Immediate cause	Greased cartridges, Enfield rifle
Revolt began	Meerut, 10 May 1857
Nursery of the Bengal Army	Awadh
Symbol of the revolt	Lotus & chapati
Savarkar vs Majumdar	"First War of Independence" vs "neither first, national, nor a war"
Crown takeover proclaimed	1 Nov 1858, Lord Canning
Only 1858 promise actually kept	Abolition of Doctrine of Lapse
Revolt fully suppressed by	1859

21 PYQs from the Video (with Answers)

1. When was the Enfield rifle with greased cartridges introduced into the British Indian Army?

Ans: December 1856

2. What was the main proximate cause of the First War of Independence?

Ans: Military discontent over religious interference (greased cartridges)

3. Which title did Bahadur Shah Zafar give to Bakht Khan?

Ans: Shahab-e-Alam Bahadur

4. Who was Birjis Qadar?

Ans: Son of Begum Hazrat Mahal

5. Who was the Times of London correspondent who wrote critically about how North Indians viewed the "white man"?

Ans: W.H. Russell

6. Where did the 1857 revolt first begin?

Ans: Meerut

7. What was the symbol of the 1857 freedom struggle?

Ans: Lotus flower and chapati

8. Which centre did the British recapture first among the revolt's centres?

Ans: Delhi

9. Who led the Bareilly revolt of 1857?

Ans: Khan Bahadur Khan

10. Where was Birjis Qadar's mother, Begum Hazrat Mahal, from?

Ans: Lucknow/Awadh

11. Under whose leadership did the 1857 revolt advance in Lucknow?

Ans: Begum Hazrat Mahal

12. Where was the maximum number of sepoys who took part in 1857 from?

Ans: Awadh

13. Who was betrayed by a friend and killed by the British?

Ans: Taty Tope (betrayed by Man Singh, killed 1859)

14. Whose real name was Ramchandra Pandurang?

Ans: Taty Tope

15. From where did Kunwar Singh lead the revolt?

Ans: Bihar (Jagdishpur/Arrah)

16. Which dynasty gave the British the most support during 1857?

Ans: The Scindias of Gwalior

17. Match: Kunwar Singh, Nana Saheb, Bakht Khan, Maulvi Ahmad — to Bihar, Kanpur, Delhi, Awadh.

Ans: Kunwar Singh-Bihar, Nana Saheb-Kanpur, Bakht Khan-Delhi, Maulvi Ahmad-Awadh

18. Who was Governor-General of India during the Revolt of 1857?

Ans: Lord Canning

19. What was the main reason the 1857 revolt failed?

Ans: Lack of unity among the rebels

20. Which British officers lost their lives at Lucknow?

Ans: General Neill, General Havelock, and Henry Lawrence

21. Who described the 1857 revolt as a "Sepoy Mutiny"?

Ans: T.R. Holmes

22. Who called it a war between "barbarism and civilisation"?

Ans: T.R. Holmes

23. Who called it "a war of fanatics against Christians"?

Ans: L.E.R. Rees

24. Who called it a "Muslim conspiracy against the British"?

Ans: Outram and Taylor

25. Which modern historian called 1857 India's "First War of Independence"?

Ans: V.D. Savarkar

26. Who was the official historian of the Indian freedom movement?

Ans: S.N. Sen

27. Who was the first Indian to write, in an Indian language, about the causes of 1857?

Ans: Sir Syed Ahmad Khan (Urdu, 1859, "Asbab-e-Baghawat-e-Hind")

28. Which statement about 1857 is correct: "It was neither first, national, nor a war of independence"?

Ans: Attributed to R.C. Majumdar

29. When did Queen Victoria's proclamation bring India under British Crown control?

Ans: 1 November 1858

30. Which of Victoria's 1858 promises was actually fulfilled?

Ans: Abolition of the Doctrine of Lapse

31. Which commission was formed after 1857 to reorganise the army?

Ans: Peel Commission

32. From which provinces were sepoys excluded from army recruitment after 1857?

Ans: UP and Bihar (Brahmins), and Bengal/Odisha (Bengalis/Oriyas)

33. When did the rebel leader Shah Mal die, fighting at Baraut, UP?

Ans: July 1857

34. Who painted "In Memoriam", dedicated to British women in 1857 India?

Ans: Joseph Noel Paton

35. Who painted "Relief of Lucknow"?

Ans: Thomas Jones Barker

36. By when was the 1857 revolt considered fully suppressed?

Ans: 1859

37. Who introduced the Enfield rifle with greased cartridges?

Ans: Commonly cited as Henry Hardinge (though his tenure predates 1856 — see note above)

38. Where was the "Nursery of the Bengal Army"?

Ans: Awadh

39. Which two figures helped the British during both the Santhal rebellion and 1857?

Ans: Raja Mehtab Chand (and the Scindia family)

40. In which battle did Rani Lakshmibai die?

Ans: Battle of Gwalior, 18 June 1858

41. On which date did Meerut's soldiers reach the Red Fort to meet Bahadur Shah Zafar?

Ans: 11 May 1857

42. Whose father was Peshwa Baji Rao II?

Ans: Nana Saheb

43. Where was the Battle of Chinhat fought, and why is it important?

Ans: Lucknow — Henry Lawrence's forces fought the rebels here

44. Why did the revolt succeed easily against the British in Rajput states?

Ans: Local Rajput rulers did not support the rebel forces, so the British suppressed the revolt easily there

45. Who led the 1857 revolt in Mathura (a distractor option)?

Ans: Devi Singh (not connected to Kunwar Singh's Bihar-based revolt)

E1. Which regiment/cavalry actually revolted first at Meerut on 10 May 1857?

Ans: The 3rd Bengal Light Cavalry

E2. Which officer did Mangal Pandey shoot at on 29 March 1857?

Ans: Lieutenant Henry Baugh (he also attacked a Sergeant-Major during the same incident)

E3. What was the final push by the British to retake Delhi called, and when did the city fully fall?

Ans: The Siege/Assault of Delhi; the city fell by around 20 September 1857

E4. Which British general commanded the final relief of the Lucknow Residency?

Ans: Sir Colin Campbell (November 1857)

E5. What was General Hugh Rose's famous description of Tatya Tope?

Ans: "The best and bravest military leader of the rebels"

23 Bonus — Standard-Syllabus Points (Not in the Video)

Commonly tested alongside "Revolt of 1857" but not explicitly covered in the lecture. Verified against standard references.

- **Government of India Act, 1858:** The legal instrument that formally transferred power from the East India Company to the British Crown, creating the office of Secretary of State for India — the direct legal counterpart to Canning's 1858 Proclamation.
- **Indian Councils Act, 1861:** Passed soon after the revolt, it began reintroducing a limited Indian voice into legislation — a useful "what changed politically" companion fact to the "what changed militarily" (Peel Commission) point covered above.
- **Battle of Chinhat detail:** Henry Lawrence's forces were defeated here on 30 June 1857, forcing a retreat into the Lucknow Residency, which was then besieged for months — the siege itself, not Chinhat directly, is where Lawrence succumbed to his wounds.
- **3rd Bengal Light Cavalry:** The specific Meerut unit whose 85 troopers refused to use the new cartridges on 24 April 1857 and were court-martialled — the direct trigger for the wider Meerut uprising on 10 May.

Cross-check all dates with your NCERT Class VIII "Our Past III" for the standard textbook framing.

This is **Part 6 of an 8-part series** covering the full lecture. Mahatma Gandhi is covered next in **Part 7**.